

BERNERA NEWS

A Community Newsletter **The Daily Ceilidh**
in association with

BERNERA BRIDGE UPDATE

Statement from Colin Morrison, on behalf of Comhairle nan Eilean Siar, 1st October 2020

Plans for procuring a replacement structure are progressing well and the Comhairle hopes to have information confirmed within the next week or so. Various options were considered early on in the process including a causeway type structure with a short bridge section. This could be a good permanent solution, however construction timescale discounted this in favour of a single span steel structure.

If plans proceed accordingly the Comhairle should be in a position for ground works to start later this year with installation works getting underway in January next year. However the Comhairle still has to apply for a Marine License, although we don't need to go through the 12 week pre-application process. There are also still land acquisition and planning procedures to go through.

Arrangements for waste collection are continuing and measures are in place for any necessary gritting as the winter weather approaches.

The Comhairle is undertaking a risk assessment covering all eventualities and emergency planning response. As part of this a potential sea crossing point has been identified and a trial is in the process of being arranged should this be required anytime in the future.

The Comhairle would like to assure the residents of Bernera that both the replacement bridge structure and contingency planning arrangements are receiving the highest priority.

Should you require urgent assistance meantime please call
01851 600 501

BERNERA BRIDGE.

Reference Minutes of last Meeting, submitted letter, dated 27th ultimo, from the Ministry of Transport, London, conveying the consent of the Minister of Transport under Section 34 of the Coast Protection Act, 1949, to the construction of the above bridge in accordance with the approved drawings etc.

The Committee noted the position.

The original minute approving the Bridge from Ross and Cromarty County Council Minutes of the Highways Committee of 20 March 1952.

Welcome to the 8th edition of the Bernera News. Autumn has arrived and pushed the mercury downward this week in the usual confusing way, and all thoughts here are turning to Christmas. What impact the covid-19 restrictions will have on the community is as yet unknown. There are surely many twists and turns to play out, before final decisions are made about what we can and can't do with our families and friends this year.

One of the events that probably won't be happening is the Christmas Fair. Many of our local crafters and businesses have missed the tourism season and we thought it would be great to run a virtual Art and Craft Fair in the next edition.

This will take the form of anyone interested being featured in the BN with a description of their available wares, 2 photos and contact details. All artisans will be also added to a webpage which can be shared for sales further afield amongst our friends and families. We will also help to support those without websites or payment portals, to gain additional skills or ways to reach their markets.

We'll be running a raffle too. If you would like to be included in this edition please ring us or email us before the 20th of October.

Contact us at: 01851 600 159
Text/Whatsapp: 07958 549784
Email: hello@thedailyceilidh.co.uk
Or visit us online at:
www.thedailyceilidh.co.uk

BIN COLLECTIONS AND COMMUNITY SKIP

Since the introduction of the new, smaller, bin lorry for Bernera, there is a possibility that not all bins will be serviced in one day. It is therefore asked that bins are put out as normal by 8am on Tuesday, but if your bin has not been emptied by the end of the day to leave it out for the following day.

Although now relocated to Earshader, the Community Skip continues to be open to receive household waste each Saturday from 10am to 12 noon.

BERNERA SURGERY

Surgery opening hours are currently Monday 2.30 - 5pm, and Wednesday 12noon - 5pm. For all appointments please call Langabhat Medical Practice on **01851 860222**

It is important to note that medication collection times are slightly different from the surgery opening hours. Please only attend the surgery for collection at these times:

Monday 2.30 - 5pm

Wednesday 1.30 - 4pm

Friday 11am - 12 noon

Please ensure you wear a face covering when entering the surgery, unless you are exempt.

NHS WESTERN ISLES

Cervical Screening has restarted in the Western Isles. If you think you may have missed your scheduled appointment, or are due to be seen, please get in touch with your GP practice.

NHS Western Isles have reissued guidance on staying safe in the current situation. They have asked people to refrain from wearing disposable gloves when shopping, stating "If you wear the same gloves when you shop, or touch a trolley, food, door, phone, your face or hair you are spreading germs. It's safer not to wear gloves at all."

Instead they ask you to focus on staying safe by:

- Wear a face covering in shops and on public transport.
- Wash your hands or use hand gel before entering each shop, as well as when leaving the premises.
- Maintain the recommended physical distance from others.
- Wash your hands when you arrive home.

FLU VACCINATIONS

Please note that this year's Flu Clinics are being organised and run centrally by NHS Western Isles, rather than GP Surgeries.

Residents have begun to receive appointment letters. If you have any questions then please contact **01851 763304**

Following on from the information published in last month's Bernera News, relating to adults, the flu vaccine for children this year will contain a live vaccine. The virus in the vaccine has been weakened so that it doesn't cause flu, but instead works by building up the child's immunity to the flu. For those families who have within their household, or have close contact with, an adult or child who is severely immunocompromised there is a non-live version available, which will be administered by injection rather than by the usual nasal spray.

For more information visit www.nhsinform.scot or speak to NHS Western Isles on **01851 763304**

CORONAVIRUS UPDATE

Scottish Government

From Friday 25th September new restrictions have been put in place across Scotland, aimed at reducing the growing rate of infection. These include a 10pm curfew for pubs, restaurants and bars. In addition, visiting other households indoors is no longer permitted.

Exemptions to this restriction include those living alone, or alone with children who have formed extended households; couples in non-cohabiting relationships; provision of informal childcare, e.g grandparents looking after children; tradespeople.

You can, however, currently continue to meet people outside, in your garden or a public space, in groups of up to 6 people, from no more than 2 households (not counting under-12s). It is important, though, that you stay 2 metres apart from anyone not in your household.

Comhairle nan Eilean Siar

There continues to be a dedicated service to collect details of individuals throughout the Western Isles who are looking for support during Covid-19. Those seeking help are asked to complete the Request for Support Form, found on the council website, or by calling the council on **01851 600 501**.

BREAST CANCER AWARENESS MONTH

As October is Breast Cancer Awareness Month we thought it a good opportunity to share some information about breast cancer.

The earlier breast cancer is diagnosed, the better the chance of successful treatment. So it's important to check your breasts regularly and see your GP if you notice a change.

Common breast cancer signs and symptoms in women include:

- a lump or swelling in the breast, upper chest or armpit – you might feel the lump but not see it
- a change to the skin, such as puckering or dimpling
- a change in the colour of the breast – the breast may look red or inflamed
- a change to the nipple, for example it has become pulled in (inverted)
- rash or crusting around the nipple
- any unusual liquid (discharge) from either nipple
- changes in size or shape of the breast

On its own, pain in your breasts is not usually a sign of breast cancer. But look out for pain that's there all or most of the time.

It is important to remember that men can also get breast cancer.

The most common symptom in men is a lump in the chest area which is often painless.

Other symptoms of male breast cancer may include:

- Liquid, sometimes called discharge, that comes from the nipple without squeezing and which may be blood-stained
- A tender or inverted (pulled in) nipple
- Ulcers (sores) on the chest or nipple area
- Swelling of the chest area and occasionally the lymph nodes under the arm

Noticing an unusual change doesn't necessarily mean you have breast cancer, and most breast changes are not because of cancer. But it's important to get checked by your GP.

BERNERA MUSEUM UPDATE

Although both the Museum and Iron Age House have been closed this summer there has still been some activity taking place.

The Museum Trustees decided to take advantage of the close and have some refurbishment of the museum done. Currently the walls are being painted and over the coming months some displays will be renewed.

There is, of course, still admin to be done and volunteers are weekly going into the museum to check the premises, answer emails and queries, as well as keeping up to date on current guidelines and requirements.

The museum has a fairly extensive photo archive showing people and places of Bernera and Tir Mor and these are being shared weekly on Facebook as well as being added to the Bernera Museum website. If anyone would like to

loan photos that can be added to the archive these would be greatly welcomed.

During the drier parts of the summer, and there has been some, the committee members have been taking it in turn to check on the Iron Age House and water the roof as needed, to help keep the turf fresh and growing. This is particularly important on the southern end which is steeper and faces the sun and prevailing winds.



A small grant from Paths For All has been given to the

Museum so that repair work to the path above the Iron Age Village can be done. This path is the main route taken to the Iron Age House and the dunes have seen a fair bit of erosion the last few years. The work should be completed before the winter sets in.

The museum has been taking part in the European Maritime and Coastal Heritage Project, a web based database of places, stories and heritage which can be used for both private visit planning and academic research. The website can be found at

<https://mapyourheritage.eu/>.

Finally, it is hoped that both the Museum and Iron Age House will reopen in May next year, depending upon the health and safety requirements to keep all safe from Covid 19.

Colin Halliday
Kirkibost



BERNERA BAKES... CHERRY BAKEWELL

Ingredients:

500g sweet shortcrust pastry
6-8 tbsp cherry jam / mincemeat
200g butter, softened
200g caster sugar
4 medium eggs
100g ground almonds
100g self raising flour, plus extra for dusting
1-2 tsp almond extract
300g icing sugar
20 glacé cherries, optional
25g flaked almonds

Method:

Preheat the oven to 200°C/Fan 180°C/Gas 6. On a lightly floured surface, roll out the pastry to fit a 30cmx20cm baking tray. Spread

the jam/mincemeat over base.

Whisk the butter and caster sugar in a large bowl until smooth and creamy. Beat in the eggs one at a time, with 1tbsp of ground almonds with each egg.

Add flour, remaining almonds, almond extract, and stir well. Spoon the mixture over the jam/mincemeat, in an even layer.

Bake for 35-40 mins until well risen, firm and golden. Remove from the oven and leave to cool in the tin. Lightly toast the almond flakes in a hot pan, until golden.

Mix together the icing sugar and 3tbsp water to make a fairly thick

icing. When the tart is cold, spread the icing on top evenly.

Decorate with glacé cherries and flaked almonds and leave to set. Cut the tart into squares or rectangles and serve.



Dolina Macleod
Crulivig



ON THE SOFA... KEVIN LONG, THE ISLAND PLUMBER

Kevin Long is a plumbing and heating engineer with over 40 years experience in installations and building alterations. He joined us on the “socially distanced” sofa to chat about himself, his business, and life on the Island. He is also the Stornoway BID Steering group Chair.

Kevin lives in Breacleite with his wife Sue, and their menagerie of animals: 4 dogs, including 2 Newfoundlands, Highland cows and Valais Blacknose Sheep. He found himself following Sue as she returned to her island roots, and they ended up buying the house and croft that they rented after leaving Merseyside. He fell in love with the community, their new lifestyle and the richness of the life here, midges aside. As a result his business, The Island Plumber, allows him, for the first time in his working life, to have a really healthy work life balance, and he has had time to evaluate what he works for and why.

This is largely because he has been able to combine croftlife with his plumbing skills to create a good balance, which focuses on the needs of the community, amongst whom he lives. He loves meeting new people and serving their needs, whether that is advice, repairs or installations.

“In a larger city or suburb it’s hard to connect in such a personal way as a jobbing plumber.”

At the heart of our chat, Kevin, whose dyslexia has shaped his early career and eventually his successes, revealed that he is a devoted Rotarian. Indeed his Rotary projects are his proudest moments, pushing him to continue to try to impact lives, regardless of the personal cost. This means that working to serve the communities he is part of, is at the heart of his motivation..

“There’s a trust you build with a client over time, and it’s such a great feeling of pride when we hit the sweet spot of my expertise and their trust.”

He covers Bernera and Uig and will travel further for friends of local clients. You can contact him on **01851 612346**.



In the next issue, our On the Sofa feature will be replaced by the virtual arts and crafts fair. If you'd like to join us for a friendly chat about your business or organisation for the December edition, please ring Julia on 07894516609.

POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLANDS...



We wanted to tell you a little bit about our holiday to Spain to see our Spanish cousins. Mum’s brother David lives in the Basque region of Spain just outside Bilbao. We were not sure if we were going to get to go to see them because of stupid COVID 19. But we did get to go and see them. We had to wear masks in the airport and on the plane, we did not like wearing the masks but we had to get used to it because we had to wear them a lot in Spain!

We enjoyed seeing our cousins, it was fun and we spent a lot of time at the beach and swam in the sea loads! Carrie enjoyed swimming like a dolphin underwater. I enjoyed swimming under the waves, it was great fun. When we came home to Lewis we had to stay at home for 14 days, we were very grateful for having a croft to run around in.

Lots of Love, Ava and Carrie xxx

GREAT BERNERA COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT TRUST (GBCDT)

Update on Activities – September 2020

The following is an edited version of a full statement, which is readable online at www.thedailyceilidh.co.uk/trustupdate/. For those without access to the internet who would like a copy of the full statement please contact us and we will deliver a copy to you.

Buyout

Bringing 'The Crofting Lands of Bernera', the official title of the Island estate, into community ownership was the founding objective of GBCDT, and we have been working for five years to attempt to reach an agreement with the current owner.

We are now looking at the option of forcing a sale under Part 3 of the Land Reform Act, the 'Crofting Community Right to Buy'. We are currently wading through the many legal and procedural steps to allow us to submit an application to the Scottish Government. To proceed with the application we will need to have a public meeting, at which we would explain the whole process, followed by a postal ballot of all eligible voters.

Before the application can be submitted, we must secure a majority in favour, of all those who vote, and, importantly, a majority in favour, of all the crofters who vote. We are currently attempting to inform all the Bernera crofters of the process we are following, and we will try to answer any questions they might have.

It now remains to get through all the legal steps that will allow us to continue towards the meeting and ballot. While we are delayed on the buyout we are looking at other ways in which we can pursue our core objectives. Several new funding sources have opened up in recent months, and we are looking to

use them in the appointment of a local Development Officer, who would pursue the business studies, funding applications and coordination of projects on Bernera.

Kirkibost Pontoons

The funding for the pontoons and associated facilities is now all in place, and GBCDT is seeking tenders from consultants to act as Project Managers for the scheme, who in turn will issue tenders for contractors to undertake the works, manage the contract, and supervise the works.

If all proceeds according to the programme, the pontoons and facilities should be in place ready for next year's sailing season in the late spring of 2021.



Fuel Pumps

The ability to buy fuel on Bernera was once an important lifeline. The loss of that ability some years ago has been keenly felt, and efforts to restore a local fuel supply have been ongoing ever since. We are finally beginning to see some progress with the award of a Crown Estate grant of £31.5K towards the setting up of a 24 hour, card-based fuel supply, both petrol and diesel, at the site

of the old pumps by the shop in Breacleite.

Estimates of the cost of a new system of this kind put the overall cost at between £30K and £40K. Efforts are ongoing to establish a firm price for the whole system, and to then raise the balance and make Bernera fuel a reality.

Trust Meetings

The Trust directors meet on the third Thursday of every month, and Trust members are welcome to attend.

Meetings (until recently) are held in the Community Hall.

Until the Covid 19 restrictions are removed, all meetings will be virtual, by Zoom, and any member who wishes to attend will need to inform the Trust (trustbernera@hotmail.com) in advance, to enable an invite to be issued.

If you are not a member of the Trust, you are very welcome to join. Membership costs £1 per year.



Cafe Sia on Skye, with its relaxed atmosphere and small footprint, is an example of what we could have at the pier site.

HEBRIDEAN WHALE AND DOLPHIN TRUST

BY MORVEN SUMMERS, VOLUNTEER COORDINATOR

Seeing a fin break the surface of the sea fills you with a sense of wonder. People hold a fascination with whales, dolphins and porpoises (collectively known as cetaceans) and are intrigued by their lives beneath the waves. Perhaps it's the commonality of being mammals, yet inhabiting such different worlds that holds our imagination?

The Hebrides are a truly fantastic place, where the waters are rich and home to amazing biodiversity. A quarter of the global cetacean species count have been recorded here, including ocean giants such as the humpback and the fin whale – the second largest animal on the planet! The waters off the west coast of Scotland are home to some of the highest densities of harbour porpoise in Europe, and supports resident populations of bottlenose dolphin, white beaked dolphin and the unique and highly vulnerable group of orca known as the West Coast Community.

Seasonal visitors arrive on masse in the spring and include the minke whale – the smallest of the baleen whales – common dolphin and basking shark. The migratory pattern of the minke whale is still uncertain, but some individuals return to the same areas year after year (for over a decade in some cases) and are well known to researchers. Common dolphins – relatively uncommon a decade ago – now appear in super-pods, stretching as far as

the eye can see.

Although wild, beautiful and seemingly pristine, Hebridean seas are under threat from the impact of human activity. Marine mammals are threatened by climate change, entanglement, pollution, underwater noise and habitat degradation. Changes are happening in our marine environment and gathering data is crucial to understanding these creatures and how we should best protect them.

The Hebridean Whale and Dolphin Trust (HWDT) has been



collecting data off the west coast of Scotland for over 25 years. This data, and the information it provides, is key to improving our understanding of the different species and, through people getting involved, we have built huge databases which can be used to deepen our knowledge.

Anyone can join in...through Whale Track, people with a passion for wildlife can get involved in helping protect it.

Whale Track is the tool the Trust uses to receive sightings reports from the public. With such a varied coastline and an amazing number of sea lochs

and bays, it's difficult on the west coast to track what's been seen and where. However, with the help of citizen scientists – people who get involved with data collection programmes – a fuller understanding is achieved. There's a free and really easy to use app which you can use to report sightings – the app also includes a handy identification guide and logs all your sightings onto a map. You can also report sightings directly through the website, again there is an interactive map which is a great resource to explore what's been seen and where.

For more information about Whale Track, please visit <https://whaletrack.hwdt.org/>

There is still so much to learn about the seas and the animals which live there. It is only through continued long-term monitoring that we can fill those gaps in our knowledge. Conservation is driven by people and through citizen science, people are more involved than ever – last year more people than ever joined HWDT to report their sightings through Whale Track.

Join in and get involved directly with helping protect our beautiful Hebridean seas.



TOO GOOD TO BE TRUE!

As I sat down to write this small article I looked at my computer screen and I saw down on the taskbar I had mail. Instinctively I opened the mail, reading the latest emails before, out of habit, I checked my 'spam' folder, just in case any messages sent to me had been electronically 'shedded' into this folder.

And there it was. A message from someone whom I have never met before in my life, acknowledging that we had never met, before going on to tell me that I was not only on the verge of becoming a millionaire but a multi-millionaire.

My sudden financial elevation resulting from a person I had no knowledge of, or relation to, kindly bequeathing £11.4 million to me. All I had to do was simply forward my bank details and the monies would immediately be transferred by BACS payment into my bank account.

"Too good to be true!" you might say. "Fake news!" you might cry.

Well, on both counts you are right, but how tempting to have just done what was asked for. Instinctively I knew that it must be false, but greed and avarice raise their ugly heads to argue with one's conscience, to be persuaded by a process of illogical logic in trying to justify the unjustifiable. Goaded on by a sinful aspiration, that hoping against hope that the circle could be impossibly squared. After all, what could I, or you, not do with £11.4 million!

Yet, in reality, this apparent financial bonanza was nothing more than 'spam' mail, better understood perhaps as a deceitful 'scam'. Such 'scams' are simple to prepare and are founded upon fallen man's inherent greed, both in the preparation, presentation and receipt of such an unbelievable offer.



Evil people preying on the most vulnerable in society to steal their hard-earned income and life-long savings by deceiving them into believing a lie.

It is little wonder that the Bible teaches us that *'the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil, for which some have strayed from the faith in their greediness, and pierced themselves through with many sorrows.'* **2 Timothy 6:10.**

A wise instruction not only for the person not yet believing in Jesus, but also for the Christian who does.

Rev Hugh Maurice Stewart
Uig & Bernera



CHURCH UPDATE

It is with humble thanksgiving to God, and with faithful expectation, that we are pleased to inform everyone that our Church in Bernera will open on Wednesday 28th October 2020, assuming that things remain as they are at present.

Special measures will be in place to protect everyone's health, and your assistance in this is much appreciated.